

To: County of Vulcan Council

May 28, 2026

**Subject: Letter of Objection – Proposed Palliser Grid AI Data Centre Campus
Bylaw 2026-007**

Dear Members of Council,

I am writing to you to oppose the proposed land use re-designation from rural to industrial for the proposed AI Data Center Campus – Bylaw 2026-007.

It is my respectful submission that the proposed re-designation is inconsistent with Vulcan County's existing planning framework, including the purposes and intent of the County's land Use Bylaw No. 2020-028, and therefore should not be approved.

Rural Industrial – RI Purpose

The Vulcan County's Land Use Bylaw No. 2020-028, Rural Industrial - RI states that its purpose is *"to allow industrial uses to be located in rural areas provided they do not pose a threat to the environment or create a potential nuisance for residents"*. The proposed Bylaw 2026-007 contradicts the Rural Industrial purpose as stated and creates both a threat to the environment and a potential nuisance for residents.

- The proposed Data Processing Operation means a heavily industrial facility will be located on this site. These lands fall within the Vulcan County's Environmentally Significant Area (ESA) and due to this overlap, is deemed a threat to the environment. See Vulcan County Municipal Development Plan ESA Map 24 attached.
- It will also create a Nuisance through the emissions of noise, smoke, dust, odour, heat, light, fire hazard, etc. See Administrative Definitions of a Nuisance – Vulcan County Land Use Bylaw 2020-028 as per below:

NUISANCE means anything that is obnoxious, offensive or interferes with the use or enjoyment of property, endangers personal health and safety, or is offensive to the senses. This could include that which creates or is liable to create a nuisance through emission of noise, smoke, dust, odour, heat, light, fumes, vibration, fire or explosive hazard; results in the unsightly or unsafe storage of goods, salvage, junk, waste or other material; or poses a hazard to health and safety.

The proposed Palliser Grid project is inappropriately sited and represents an incompatible land use as it is located within an ESA and within one mile of recreational lands - areas that are expressly protected under existing County policy. Viable and more appropriate alternative locations exist to the northeast, which would place the project at a greater distance from these protected areas. Additionally, these locations would consolidate the project within an already industrialized area (adjacent to existing wind and solar developments) thus reducing the cumulative effects of industrialization. See Vulcan County Map 19 Resources attached.

In a project of this magnitude, land acquisition costs are comparatively insignificant. Site selection should not be driven solely by the convenience of land ownership by the proponent. Rather, the proponent should identify an appropriate site consistent with County planning policy and acquire or lease the necessary lands accordingly.

Section 13 Industrial Siting Standards

SECTION 13 INDUSTRIAL SITING STANDARDS

- 13.1 A proposed grouped industrial development or an isolated industrial development considered by the Development Authority to be potentially hazardous, unsightly or offensive should not be approved within 1.6 km (1 mile) of:
- (a) an incorporated urban municipality;
 - (b) a hamlet;
 - (c) a provincial, regional, municipal park or recreation area;
 - (d) an environmentally significant area;
 - (e) an existing or approved rural residence.
- 13.2 The above restrictions also apply:
- (a) within 152.4 m (500 ft) of either side of a provincial highway or a designated scenic, tourist or recreational access road as established in a Vulcan County bylaw;
 - (b) within such distance of other roads as established by any Vulcan County bylaw;
 - (c) adjacent to a water body.

Potentially Hazardous

Section 13.1 of the Land Use Bylaw further provides that industrial developments shall not be potentially hazardous where located near sensitive or populated areas.

This concern is particularly significant given the fire risks associated with the proposed project, especially in combination with the fire history of the adjacent solar farm.

There have been previous incidents of grassfires at the Travers Solar site, as recently as March 7th, 2026 where a significant fire was attended by fire services of no less than six local communities. The exact location was confirmed as starting in the solar panels on the SE 7-15-20W4. This fire exhibited fast-moving behavior and jumped RGE RD 205 and consumed approximately 160 acres before it was contained. Source: Freedom of Information and Protection of Privacy Act (ATIA S. 19 and ATIA S. 20).

The AI Data Center is proposing to utilize a Battery Energy Storage System (BESS). Lithium-ion battery fires are known to burn at very high temperatures, release toxic gases, can re-ignite after appearing controlled and are more difficult and hazardous to fight (International Fire & Safety Journal, April 30, 2026). Additionally, there is a risk of thermal runaway with these types of batteries.

There is a single point of egress from the SABC & Little Bow Resort. At the speed given above, a serious grassfire could reach that egress point (the intersection of Highway 529 and Range Road 212) within a few minutes, blocking off access to the highway and ultimate evacuation. Consequently, there is significant public safety risk to residents, visitors, and children attending camp activities. The proximity of this AI Data Center to our egress point is a large concern.

Bylaw 2026-007 is potentially hazardous to the residents of the SABC and LBR communities.

Unightly or Offensive

There is no official legal definition for "unightly or offensive" land use in Alberta provincial legislation. Instead, the term is commonly used as a catch-all in municipal Land Use Bylaws referring to uses that create public nuisances that interfere with the normal use, enjoyment, or value of the neighboring properties – as per the nuisance definition above.

13.1 states that developments in proximity to sensitive areas must not be unightly or offensive. Given the nature of the proposed development and the high level of opposition to the project, one would reasonably assume the project is viewed as unightly and offensive to the residents that are impacted by this AI datacenter.

I also understand that the proponent has indicated that berming and tree planting will be used to mitigate the visual impact of the proposed industrial development.

This proposal fails to account for the topographical realities of the site (see topography map and photo of the steep grade at end of this letter). The subject lands are situated on a prominent hillside with an approximate vertical elevation gain of 25 metres (82 feet). When combined with the proposed 35-foot structure, effective visual screening would require a berm approaching 120 feet in height. Such a measure is patently unreasonable and impractical, thereby underscoring the significant and unavoidable visual impact of the development, which will remain both prominent and detrimental to the surrounding landscape.

In this case, the effectiveness of berming is central to determining whether the proposal complies with that standard being met. At present, this appears to be based solely on the proponent's assertion, rather than on objective, verifiable evidence.

Given the importance of this issue, I respectfully request that Council require the applicant to submit a **professional visual impact assessment** prior to making a final decision. Such a study should include:

- Cross-sectional drawings illustrating proposed berm heights relative to surrounding viewpoints
- Line-of-sight analysis from key public and residential vantage points
- Photo simulations or visual renderings of the fully developed site
- Existing and proposed elevation data

See example below of an AI visualization of a 35 ft tall data center and natural gas power generating facility that is one mile long and on the proposed land. The overlay picture has been taken from the LBR boat lockers facing north towards the Southern Alberta Bible Camp.

An AI visualization of the proposed Data Center's unsightly & offensive impact on the reservoir

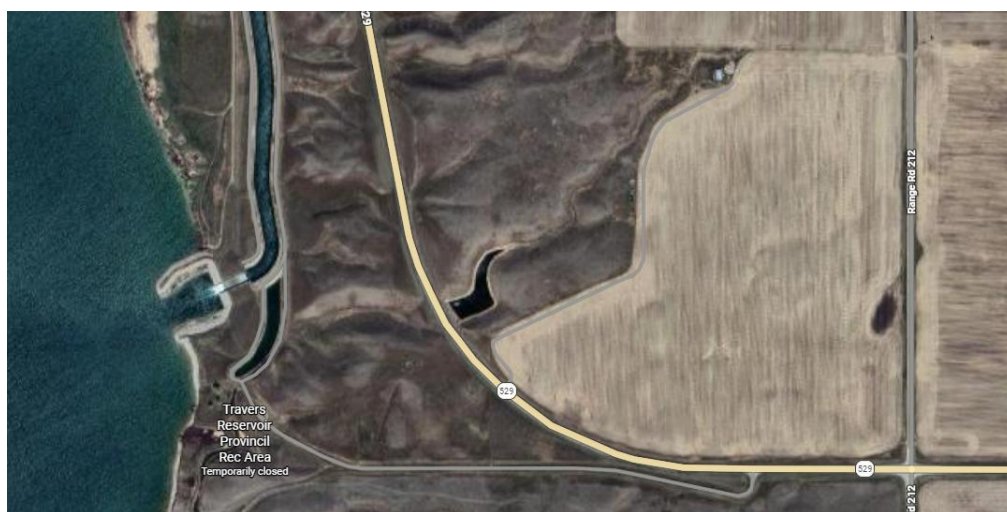


Without this type of visual impact information, it is difficult to see how Council can confidently determine compliance with Section 13.1 or ensure that its decision is well-supported and defensible.

This request is intended to ensure that Council has the necessary information to make a fully informed decision that aligns with its own bylaws and the long-term interests of the community.

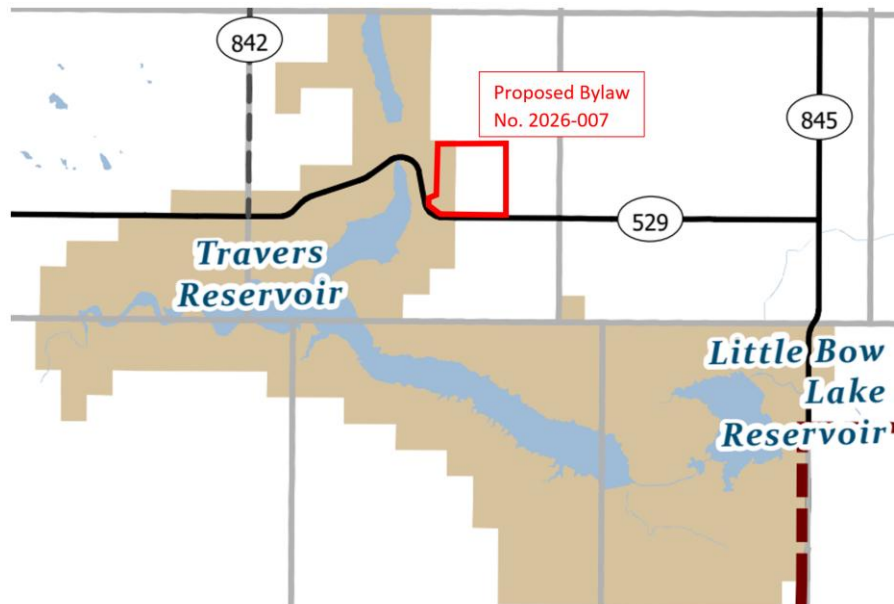
Within One Mile of A Provincial, regional, Municipal Park or Recreation Area

The project is located within one mile of the Travers Reservoir Provincial Rec Area and conflicts with the Vulcan County Industrial Siting Standards. Source: Google Maps



Environmentally Significant Area

The project is located within an Environmentally Significant Area and conflicts with the Vulcan County Industrial Siting Standards. The east side of section 15-15-21W4 is within the ESA. Section 14-15-21W4 is also within one mile of the ESA. See Map 24 - Environmentally Sensitive Areas attached.



Adjacent to a Water Body

The project is also located adjacent to a water body – the Travers Reservoir and again, conflicts with the Vulcan County Industrial Siting Standards. See above Google Maps.

Land Use for the Associated Pump Station and Pipeline Not Contemplated

The County of Vulcan has erred in not including the land use associated with the pumping station and the associated pipeline in this Bylaw. Palliser Grid has stated the water requirements for this project are to be taken from the Travers Reservoir, but have not provided details nor location of the pump station. The pump station will most likely need to be proximal to the Travers Reservoir which is contemplated in the Vulcan County Reservoir Area Structure Plan. The County must evaluate a development based on its full scope and impacts.

The pumping station is an essential component of the proposed development and is not disclosed, evaluated, nor included in the land use decision. Its location near the reservoir, recreational areas, and environmentally sensitive habitat introduces significant environmental and land use impacts that are not being considered. This represents a fundamental flaw in both the application and the approval process.

Conclusion

LBR is not opposed to responsible development within the region. As a matter of fact, LBR has not intervened in prior developments, including multiple wind energy projects and the Travers Solar Farm, from which Vulcan County has derived substantial tax revenue. Notwithstanding this, the LBR community has borne the cumulative impacts of such developments with minimal, if any, corresponding benefit. Community benefit commitments previously advanced by project proponents have ultimately proven to be illusory. The result has been a permanently altered landscape, to the detriment of the natural prairie environment and its visual character.

There is an inherent cost associated with environmental stewardship, and this matter represents a critical threshold. The cumulative effects of existing wind and solar developments, combined with the proposed data centre and associated power infrastructure, are substantial and concerning. The approval of such projects in sensitive areas risks the complete erosion of remaining natural views and sensitive environmental eco-structure. A comparison of the region's landscape over the past decade clearly demonstrates significant and irreversible change that has occurred (see attached Vulcan County Municipal Development Plan Map 19 Resources).

The proposed project is inappropriately sited and should not be expedited nor advanced through political means. The re-designation is inconsistent with Vulcan County's existing planning framework, including the purposes and intent of the County's land Use Bylaw No. 2020-028, and therefore should not be approved.

I also request that this correspondence be included in the official record for Bylaw 2026-007.

Thank you for your attention to this matter. I look forward to your response.

Sincerely,

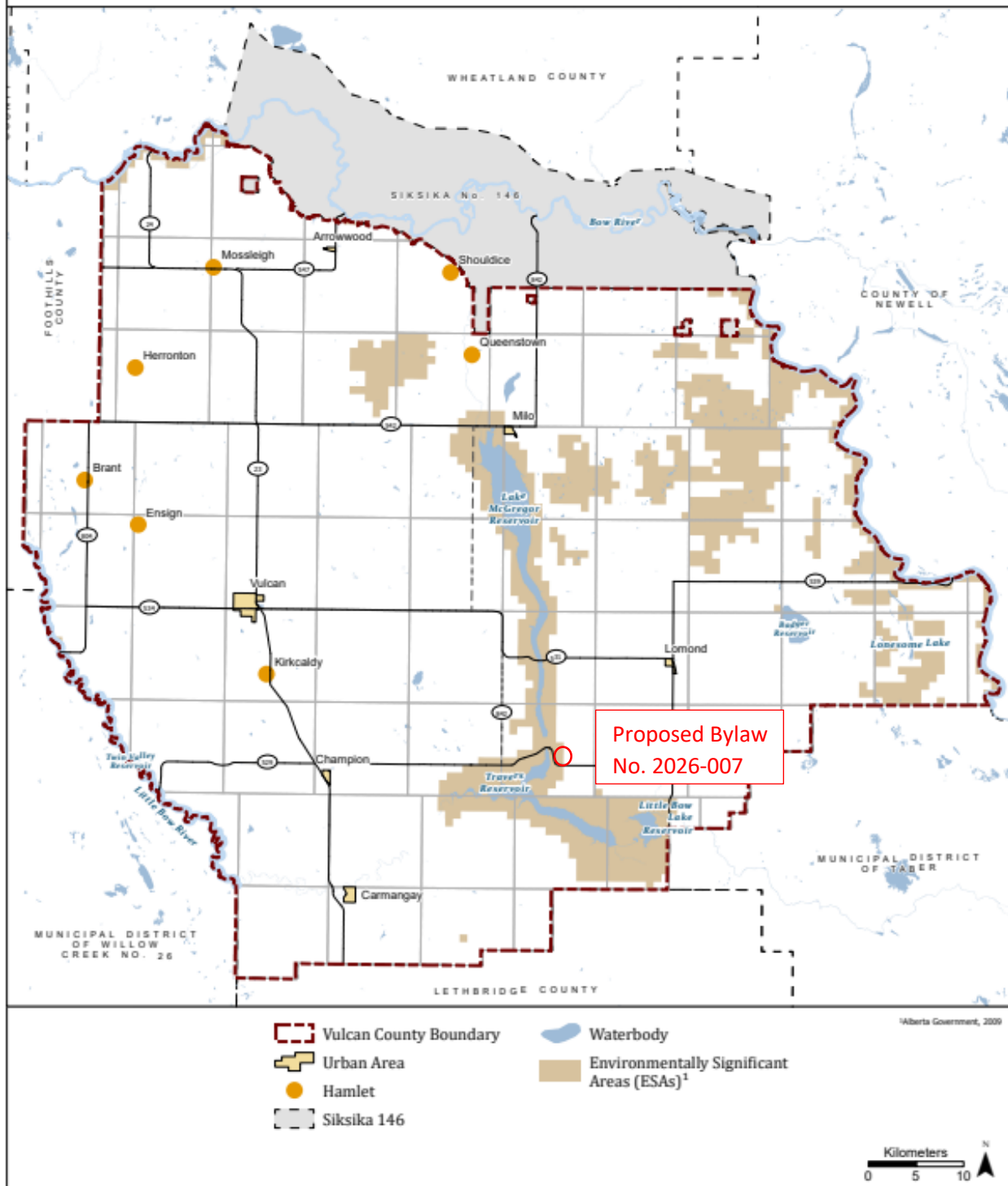
On Behalf of the LBR AI Data Center Committee

David Anderson
724 Lakeside Drive, LBR

CC:

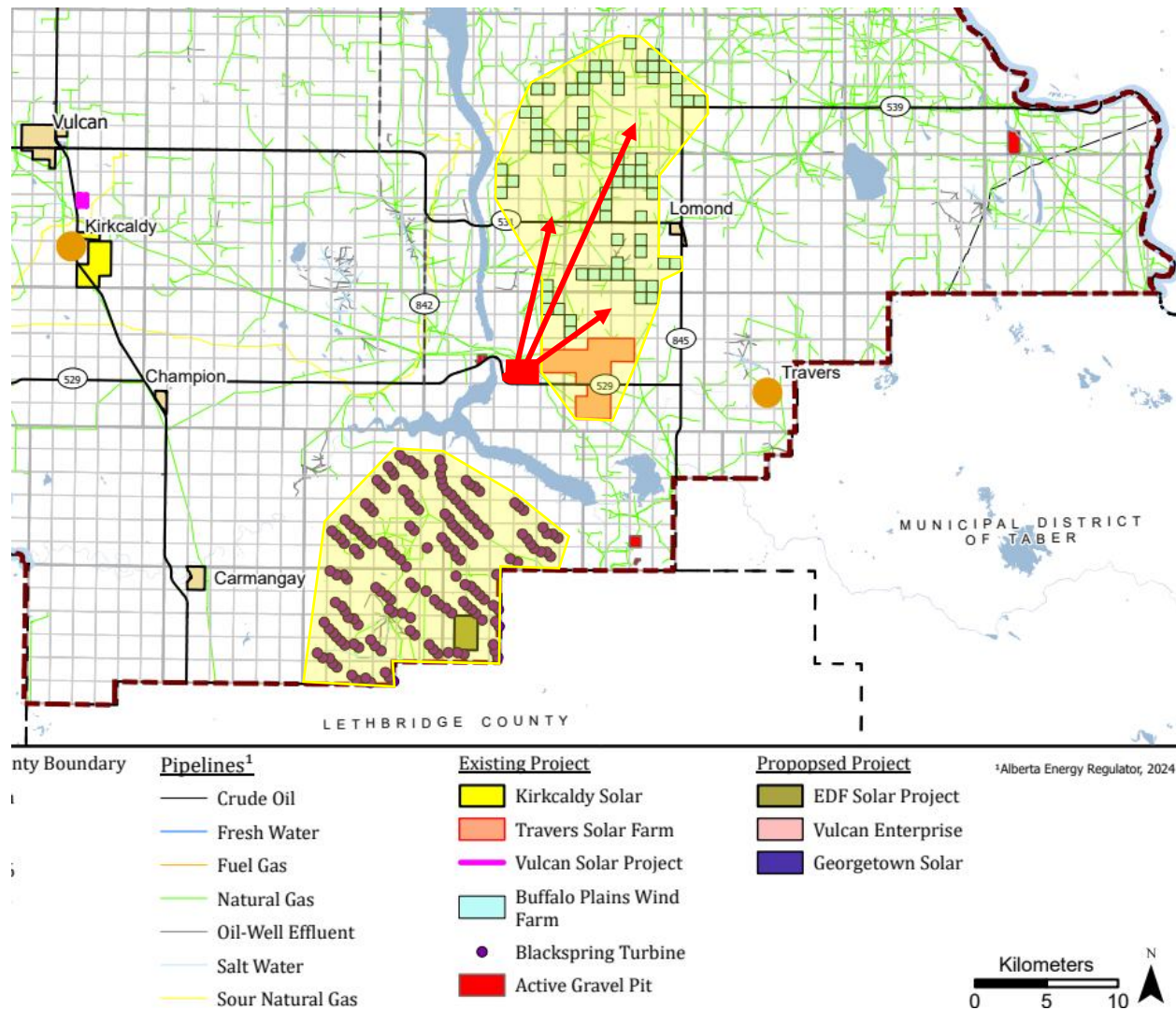
Jason Schneider, Reeve, Division 3
Doug Logan, Division 7
Jodie Gateman, Division 1
Alex Horkoff, Division 2
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Vulcan County Municipal Development Plan – Map 19 Resources

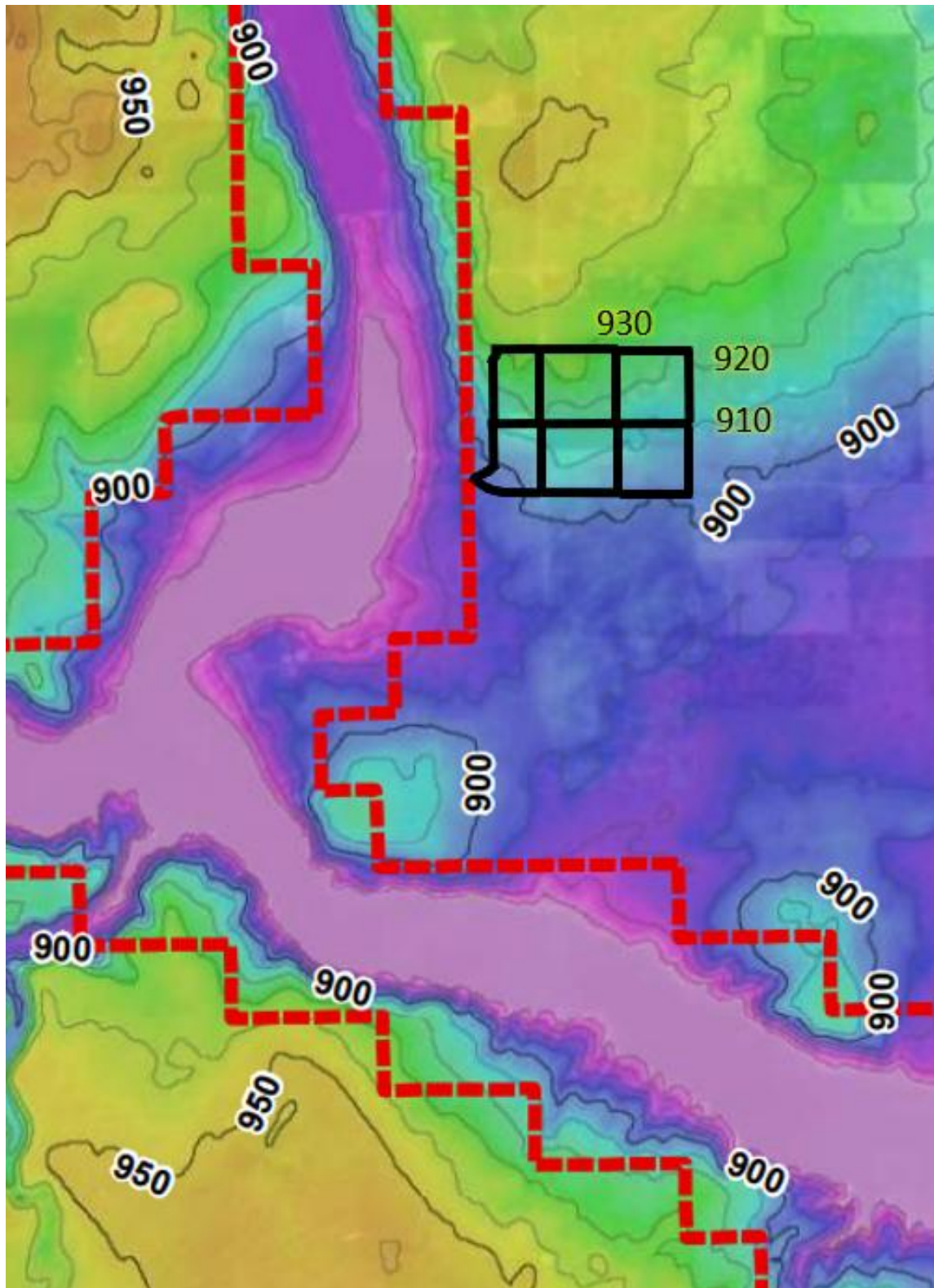
Bylaw No. 2025-011



Note: The proposed project is increasing the cumulative affects of industrialization vs containing it within the existing developed corridor.

Topography map as sourced from the Vulcan County Reservoir Area Structure Plan 2020-015

Proposed land use change area approximated in black outline.



Picture taken at top of hill at approximate 930m contour line showing steep grade of area. Note semi-truck at intersection for relative size comparison.

